Suitkeep: a one-player lane duel with a standard deck

Players: 1 · **Time:** 10 minutes · **You need:** one standard 52-card deck (no jokers). No pen, no counters, no dice. Only 22 cards are in play.

You play against an automaton: a simple, fixed set of rules runs the enemy, so you never have to make decisions for it.

Every card is a soldier. You play the **black** cards, the enemy plays the **red** ones. You send soldiers down two lanes, the enemy sends two cards a round, they clash, and survivors attack the towers. Skill gives a big edge; luck still decides some games. A careful player wins most games, but not all.

Companion app (optional): the table guide runs the enemy for you and tells you exactly what to move each step. The rules below are complete without it.

The sections are named like the topics of the app's How to play: **Goal, Fights, Your turn, A round, Towers, Last stand, Your pile**.

Goal

Destroy the enemy's **king tower** before it destroys yours. Each side has three towers of **1 card**: the **left**, the **right** and the **king**. The king can only be hit through a lane whose side tower is gone. If both kings fall in the same round, count your side towers left against the enemy's: **more left wins**, equal is a draw.

Fights

Rank: A=1, 2–10 face value, J=11, Q=12, K=13. When two cards fight, the **higher rank wins** and the loser goes to the bottom of its owner's pile (see **Your pile**). **Equal:** the enemy wins. Ties always go to the enemy, at towers too. Suits only matter for the wheel, and aces only against Kings.

Suit wheel

In a fight (and a tower hit, which is a fight too), a card **counts double** against the suit it beats: ♠ beats ♥ · ♥ beats ♦ · ♦ beats ♣ · ♣ beats ♠. Between you and the enemy only two of these count: **your ♠ beats its ♥**, and **its ♦ beats your ♣**. ♠ against ♦ and ♣ against ♥: nobody doubles. Example: 6♠ against J♥ fights as 12 and wins; against Q♥ it is equal, so the Q♥ wins.

Aces beat Kings

In a fight, an **ace beats a K**, whatever the suits. (J and Q are ordinary cards: they beat an ace.) It works both ways: an enemy ace kills your king. It counts against towers too: an ace on a tower stops a K.

Your turn

Each round you play **1 card**, or **2 small cards** (A to 5). You may also play nothing. Nothing carries over to the next round, so there is nothing to count or keep track of.

The enemy plays **2 cards every round**: the top two of its pile, whatever they are.

Setup (52 = 11 + 11 + 30 in the box)

1. Sort the deck into **black** (♠ ♣) and **red** (♥ ♦).
2. **Your cards:** shuffle the black pile and take the top **11**. Look at them.
3. **Enemy cards:** turn the red pile face-down, shuffle it and deal **11** face-down without looking. Put the **other 30 cards** (15 black, 15 red) back in the box without looking: they sit this game out, so you never know which red cards the enemy has.

4. **Your 11:** choose **8 as your deck**; the other 3 are your **towers**, one card each: **left**, **right**, **king**.
    - Tip: keep your strong cards. Decks with 4 or more big cards (6 to K) win most; a deck of only small cards loses. A good start: your **4 highest and 4 lowest** in the deck, the **3 in the middle** as towers, the highest of them on the king.
5. Shuffle your 8 deck cards. Take 3 as your **hand**; the other 5 are your **queue**, a face-up stack: its top card is the next one you draw.
6. **Enemy 11:** without looking, 8 form its **pile** (face-down); 3 form its towers (**left, right, king**), face-down. Turn the **top card of its pile face-up**: the enemy's top card is always face-up, so you always know the first card it plays next.
7. **Table:** your towers in a row in front of you (left, king, right), your queue on their left and your discard on their right; the enemy's the same way across the table (its pile on your left, its discard on your right). Two lanes (left, right) between the tower rows. Each lane has **3 slots**: slot 1 next to you, slot 2 in the middle, slot 3 next to the enemy. Several cards may share a slot, yours and the enemy's: the colour says whose a card is. Cards in a lane are **units**.

A round

1. **You play.** 1 card, or 2 small cards (A to 5), or nothing: put each in **slot 1** of a lane, and refill your hand to 3 from the top of your queue.
2. **Enemy plays (automaton).** It plays **2 cards**, each the top of its pile at the time, into **slot 3**:
    - the **first** into the **lane where you have more units** (tie: the lane with your highest-ranked unit, an ace counting as the lowest rank; still tied, left), so it defends against your biggest push;
    - the **second** into the **other lane**. Then turn its next top card face-up: that is its first play next round.
3. **Fight.** In each lane with units from both sides, your front-most unit fights the enemy's front-most where they stand, if they are in the same slot or next to each other (front-most = furthest advanced; in a shared slot, the one that got there first). Nothing has moved yet. They fight as in **Fights**.
    - The winner stays where it is. The next unit behind the loser **steps up one slot** (that is its move this round; if an enemy card is in its own slot, it stays) and fights the winner, and so on until one side has no units left in that lane.
4. **Move.** Every unit that hasn't moved this round steps one slot toward the other side. Cards never pass through each other. A unit that steps past the last slot is **at the tower**. Units already at a tower stay there.
5. **Tower hits.** Left lane first, then right. Every unit at the tower hits that lane's side tower, or the king if that side tower is gone. **The king can only be hit once that lane's side tower is gone.** Each hit is resolved as in **Towers**; a side tower that falls gets a **Last stand**.
6. **End.** A king gone ends the game (see **Goal**). Otherwise start the next round.

Towers

Every tower card is **armored**: it takes **two hits**. The first hit **cracks** it (turn it sideways); the next hit **breaks** it (discard it), whatever card hits it.

A hit is still a fight against the tower card (turn an enemy tower card face-up), with the same rules as **Fights** (the wheel doubles, an ace beats a K). The fight decides what happens to the unit:

- The unit **wins** (a tie goes to the enemy: an enemy unit that ties your tower card wins, yours that ties an enemy tower card loses): it stays at the tower, **turned sideways: it is wounded**. It hits **once more** next round (unless an enemy unit beats it first: it is the front-most unit in its lane, so new enemy cards fight it first), then goes to the bottom of its owner's pile whatever happens. So a strong card alone takes a tower in two rounds, if nothing stops it.
- The unit **loses**: the tower **shoots it back** to the bottom of its owner's pile, but the tower card still cracks (face-up if it is an enemy card). So every tower can be worn down, even by small cards.

The enemy hits your towers the same way. You know your own cards.

Last stand

When a left or right tower falls, its owner immediately places **one card in that lane for free** (it is not part of anyone's turn). You pick any card from your hand, put it in slot 1 and refill your hand. The enemy puts its face-up top card in slot 3, then turns its next top card face-up. The king has no last stand.

Your pile

A card that loses a fight, is shot back by a tower, or is a wounded unit after its second hit goes to the **bottom of its owner's pile** (the enemy's goes face-up: you know it now). Whenever one of your cards returns to your queue, refill your hand to 3. So your 8 cards keep cycling, and you will face the enemy's cards again.

Designer's notes (from thousands of simulated games)

- Expect to lose a good share of your games: the enemy is meant to be a real threat. Measured over thousands of simulated games: following the companion app's suggestions wins about 58%, which is about where a first-time player who thinks about each move lands (checked against real playtest games); a player who makes a careless move 3 times in 10 wins about 38%, and one who always plays their strongest card about 27%. Thinking wins.
- Play the first deal. Dealing again until you like your hand (say, until you hold Q♠ and an ace) is worth about 17 points of win rate: it skips the game you were given.
- What wins: meet every enemy card coming down a lane, use two small cards when both lanes need an answer, and push a lane when the enemy's face-up next card can't beat what you send.
- Why the enemy's second card goes into the other lane: both lanes always feel pressure, and a game can't stall with every card stuck fighting in one lane.
- Games last about 8 rounds.
- Every game is winnable: armor cracks on any hit, so no deck is ever stuck against towers it can't break.
- Deck building matters, but only so far: with good play, decks with 4 to 6 big cards win about 58%, all big cards about 54%, and all small cards fall far behind (about 22%).
- Black against red is fair: in testing, swapping the colours made no real difference.
- No numbers to memorise: the wheel doubles, aces beat kings, 1 big card or 2 small ones.